

MOVING UP TO U14 RUGBY

A Guide for Players & Parents

Winchester RFC • Season 2026-27

Based on RFU Regulation 15, effective 1 August 2025



THE 5 BIGGEST CHANGES AT U14

1



15-a-side

Up from 13-a-side at
U13

2



Full-size pitch

100m × 70m (was 90m
× 60m)

3



8-man scrum

#8 can now pick up &
run

4



Lineouts begin

No lifting permitted at
U14

5



Box kicks & DGs

Full kicking game
introduced

FORMAT CHANGES: SIDE BY SIDE

	U13	U14
Players per side	13	15
Pitch size	90m × 60m	100m × 70m (full size)
Match duration	25 mins per half	25 mins per half (same)
Ball size	Size 4	Size 4 (same)
Match ends early if...	Try difference > 6	Points difference > 50
Half-game rule	Mandatory	Mandatory (same)



THE SCRUM: 6-PLAYER → 8-PLAYER

U13 SCRUM

6 players • 3-2-1 formation

- Second rows: no crutch bind — bind around hips of props
- #8 must stay bound to both second rows
- #8 CANNOT pick up from the base
- Scrum-half can pass or pick and run — NO box kick
- Push limited to 1.5m
- If scrum wheels 45° it is reset — same side puts in

U14 SCRUM ★ NEW

8 players • 3-4-1 formation

- Normal binding now permitted for locks and #8
- #8 CAN pick up from the base and run — new at U14
- Scrum-half can pass, pick, run, OR box kick — new at U14
- Defending 9 still cannot follow around scrum
- Push still limited to 1.5m
- If scrum wheels 45°, original side retains the put-in

THE LINEOUT: INTRODUCED AT U14

U13 — NO LINEOUTS

Touch restarts with a FREE PASS 10m from touch.
The ball must be passed before anyone runs.
A quick throw-in is permitted instead of the free pass.

U14 — LINEOUTS INTRODUCED

Uncontested lineouts — up to 13 players per side.
Ball must be thrown straight down the middle.
Opponents must be 10m back until invited forward.
If throw is not straight: lineout to opposing team.



IMPORTANT — NO LIFTING AT U14

A common misconception is that lifting is introduced at U14. It is not. No lifting or supporting of any kind is permitted until U15. This is a mandatory safety rule under RFU Regulation 15 Appendix 8.

THE KICKING GAME

U13 — KICKING RULES

- ✓ Kicking from hand in open play
- ✓ Kick-offs and restarts (drop kick, must go 10m)
- ✓ Players offside if in front of kicker
- ✗ Box kicks
- ✗ Drop goals
- ✗ Scrum-half box kick from scrum

U14 — KICKING RULES

- ✓ Everything that was permitted at U13 (red box)
- ✓ Box kicks — now permitted
- ✓ Drop goals in open play — now permitted
- ✓ Scrum-half can box kick from scrum
- ✓ Kick to touch from inside 22 — lineout where it crossed
- ✓ Kick to touch from outside 22 — lineout at point of exit
- ✗ 50:22 Rule does not apply – Applies from U15

Note: The 50:22 and Goal Line Drop-out (GLDO) laws do not apply until U15 in England.



FULL RULE COMPARISON — TACKLING, RUCK & PENALTIES

Area	U13	U14
Tackle height	Below armpits. Ball carrier must not dip head into opponent's headspace.	Unchanged — same law applies.
Ruck & maul	Normal laws. Maul = ball carrier + 1 from each side min. 'Use it' = 5 secs.	Same laws as U13 — no significant change at this grade.
Fly-hacking	Permitted (kicking a loose ball on the ground)	Permitted — unchanged.
Penalties	Free kicks for most offences. Opponents retire 10m.	Penalty kicks now awarded for key offences (not just free kicks). Opponents still retire 10m.
Sin bin	5 minutes	5 minutes — unchanged.
Substitutions	Rolling subs, unlimited. Players can be reused.	Rolling subs, unlimited — unchanged.
Conversions	No conversions	Place kick or drop kick — new.



WHAT STAYS THE SAME

- ✓ Ball size: still size 4 (changes to size 5 at U15)
- ✓ Match duration: still 25 minutes per half
- ✓ Rolling substitutions: unlimited, players can be reused
- ✓ Half-game rule: mandatory — every player in the squad plays at least half of available playing time
- ✓ Tackle height: below the armpits — no change
- ✓ Scrum push limit: 1.5m maximum — referee calls 'Hold the push'
- ✓ 'Use it' rule in mauls: 5 seconds — scrum to opposition for non-compliance
- ✓ Fly-hacking (kicking a loose ball) is still allowed
- ✓ 50:22 and Goal Line Drop-out laws do NOT apply — these begin at U15
- ✓ Sin bin length: 5 minutes



WHAT CHANGES BY POSITION — FORWARDS

1 & 3

Props

Now in a full 8-man contested scrum. Front row binding and technique become critical. Specific front-row coaching will be provided. Outside hips will be supported by flankers. Hip height relative to shoulder height is a key learning point. Mobility is key, support play and getting to breakdowns are key.

2

Hooker

Leads the lineout throw for the first time. Must develop a straight, accurate throw. Also hooks in contested scrums. Hybrid role as modern hookers are highly mobile, ball carrying threats.

4 & 5

Locks

Join the full 8-man scrum. Normal binding now permitted. Lineout calling and positioning becomes a key role. The beating heart of the pack unit, the engine room behind how the pack operates.

6, 7

Flanks

Defined breakdown roles in ruck and maul. Lineout positioning. Support work off scrum more structured. Poaching, disrupting, tackling – playing across the field – works very closely with No.8. At the heart of the pod system.

8

No. 8

Can now pick up from the base of the scrum and run — a major new option that didn't exist at U13. Works closely with his flankers to disrupt breakdowns, control defensive lines around the ruck and make sure the pack unit is performing. Primary ball carrier – Apex predator!

Key development points:

1. Sub Unit and pack cohesion is key
2. Ruck defence, maul defence
3. Guard/Post defensive role
4. Pod organization in attack
5. Set piece platform for starter plays
6. Mobility is key



WHAT CHANGES BY POSITION — BACKS

9

Scrum-half

Vocal, very vocal. Needs to be talking all the time. Working in close co-operation with his No.8 and his No.10. Sets the tempo of the game. Can now box kick from scrum and lineout. Wider decision-making: pass, pick, run, or kick. More responsibility at the breakdown. Can be the most influential player on the field.

10

Fly-half

Full portfolio of attacking options now available. Kick, pass and carry/run. Full kicking game opens up. Box kicks, up-and-unders, cross-field kicks, and drop goals are all now permitted. Running the game in close co-operation with the No.9 – based on zones, while at the heart of driving shape into the attack. Dictates use of starter plays from set piece.

11 &
14

Wings

Full-size pitch means far more ground to cover. Kick chase (from No.10 and back 3), kick return and counter-attack become key skills. Defensive red zone kicking from hand now an option. Key season objective will be to operate as a back three with the fullback – in what is known as a pendulum approach.

12 &
13

Centres

Larger pitch creates more space to exploit. Defensive line speed and depth management become more important. Critical that these two lead the defensive lines and tie in with players either side of them. Line “shooters” becomes a defensive “attack” option. Midfield penetration and support lines on either side of strike runners is a key development point.

15

Full-back

Receiving kicks in a full-size game is a new challenge. Counter-attack from deep, kicking out of hand, and covering kicks behind the line. Linking effectively with wingers and covering each others territory. At the core of the pendulum sub unit – the “Back 3” and must develop an understanding of being the last line of defense.

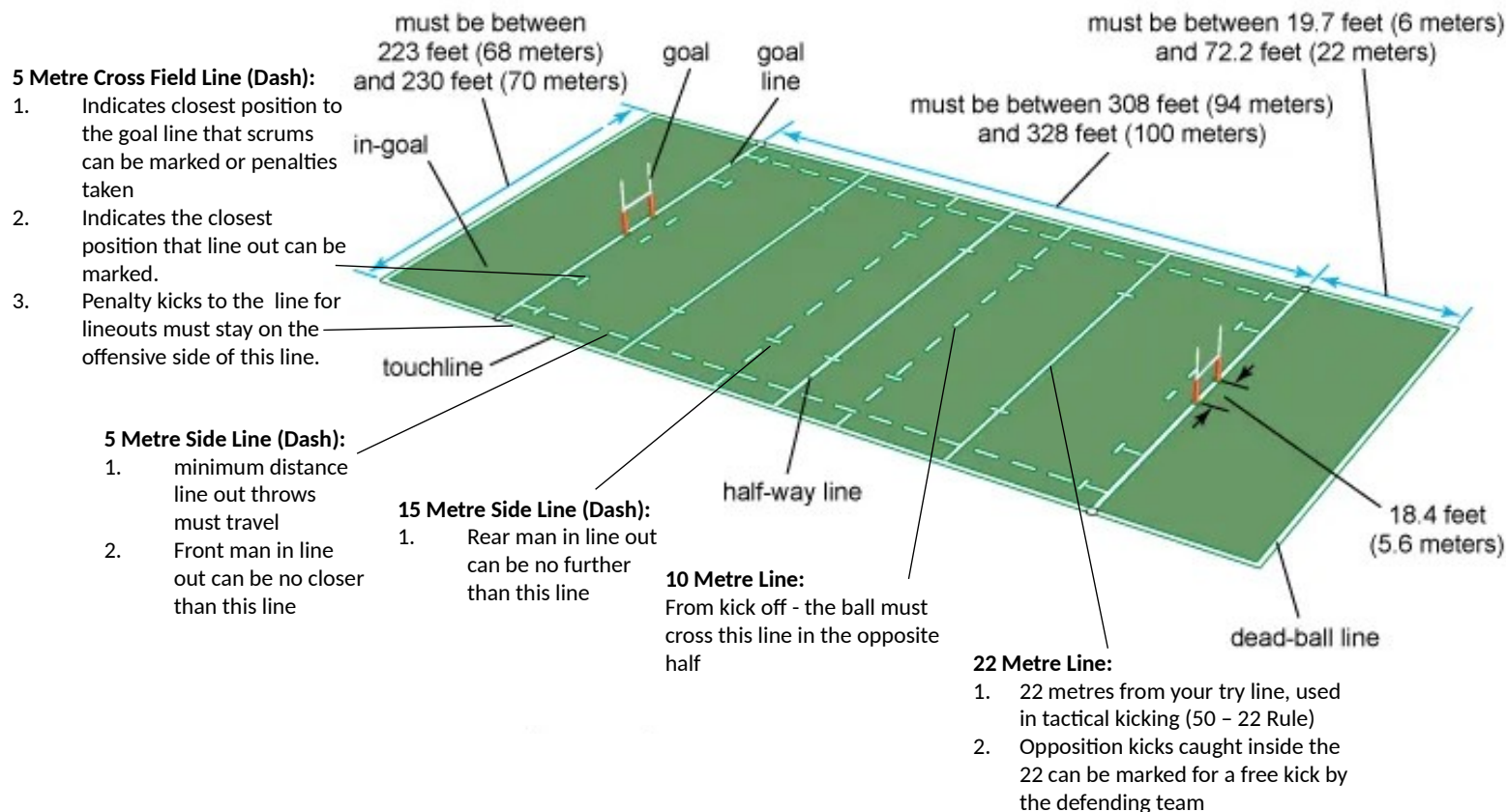
Key development points:

1. Sub Unit and backline cohesion is key
2. Shape in attack
3. Diamond formation
4. Multi phase
5. Defensive line speed as a weapon
6. Play in the right zones
7. Kicking as a pressure relief and as a weapon

Note: All backs must now be 10m back from lineouts until invited forward by the referee.



Standard Rugby Union Pitch — Line Markings



GETTING READY: PHYSICAL PREPARATION

+11%

More pitch length
90m → 100m

+17%

More pitch width
60m → 70m

+50%

More ground per player
(13 → 15 players)



- Run 2–3 times a week over the summer. Even 20-minute jogs build the aerobic base you need.
- A guide to summer conditioning will be sent out to all parents and players.



- Practice passing off both hands.
- 10 minutes with a partner makes a real difference.



- Work on core strength and lower body — squats, lunges, press-ups, burpees, chin ups.
- While tempting – compound exercise (weights) not needed yet.



- Stretching, flexibility and mobilization preferable



- Foundational approach to performance inputs become key – sleep, nutrition, hydration and where appropriate supplementation.



- These are variables that will have an impact on consistency of preparation, performance and recovery.



- Understanding what works for the individual and building this into an everyday activity will make the U14 step feel manageable



- Comprehensive, engaging and fun summer schedule to follow.



PLAYER WELFARE — FOR PARENTS



Half-game rule is mandatory

Every player in the squad must play at least half of available playing time. If this isn't happening, speak to the coach.



Scrums are closely managed

The 1.5m push limit is strictly enforced. Referees will call 'Hold the push' for non-compliance.



No lifting at U14

Lifting in lineouts is only permitted from U15 upwards. This is a mandatory safety rule.



Match ends at 50-point difference

RFU rules protect players in mismatched fixtures. Matches end automatically if the points difference reaches 50.



Medical info — please tell us

If your son has any medical condition, injury history, or welfare concern, share this with the coaching team before the season starts.



Sin bin: 5 minutes

High tackles (above armpits) and other serious offences result in a 5-minute sin bin at this age grade.



KEY CONTACTS & USEFUL LINKS

RFU Regulation 15 (all appendices)	englandrugby.com/run/rules-governance/rfu-rules-and-regulations/regulation-15-age-grade-rugby
U14 Rules of Play — Appendix 8	Available via the Regulation 15 page above
Age Grade Codes of Practice	englandrugby.com/run/coaching/age-grade-rugby/codes-of-practice
Player registration (RFU GMS)	gms.rfu.com — parent/guardian must create account first



See you on the pitch.

Let's Enjoy U14 rugby.



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